

works, and then they want to start changing and improving it. That is how they learn to be great programmers. So, if the school uses free software, the students have the opportunity to learn. If the school uses proprietary software, children don't have the opportunity to learn, because proprietary software is an enemy of education, it's opposed to the spirit of education. And thus, it doesn't belong in a school.

Q Do you think the training cost is one of the concerns? If you look at the education system, it needs investments to train teachers on the new systems?

Well yes, in order to get out of a path that is leading you to a bad destination you have to make an effort. And this is a kind of investment, social investment. Even if you ignore all the freedom and the community, the cost savings alone are worth making that investment. That is the smallest and most superficial part of why you should do it.

However, you will notice that the proponents of proprietary software encourage people to think short term, because if you think very short term it might seem that switching to free software is a lot of work and more expensive. It seems more expensive because you have to train some people at first. But that is a one-time expense. Once schools start graduating people who know free software there is no shortage of people. So, this is only a short-term expense and, therefore, those who are trying to defend proprietary software are trying to encourage a very short-term way of thinking.

Q How much sense does free software make to the enterprise segment?

Well, if you are running a business, you ought to want to have control over your computing, so you should insist on free software. Businesses get the benefits of the four freedoms just like everyone else. Not only that, there is a side effect. The support for free software is a free market. In case of proprietary software, only the developer has the source code, so if there is a bug, only the developer can fix it and thereby support is a monopoly. This means that support is usually expensive and bad. But with free software that support is available from the free market, so businesses get better support for their money. And any time they are not satisfied with their support provider they can switch to another.

Q What about developers who while using a lot of free software in the backend, release their products as proprietary software?

Well, that is unjust. Any proprietary program means that there is a user who doesn't have freedom. There is no excuse for this. Users should refuse to get subjugated in this way. They accept it because of the short-term thinking—"I want to do this now, and the only way I can do this now is to let this developer have power over me." So, what is to be done? Well, that depends on whether I am thinking short-term or long-term.

The free software movement has made it even easier to

choose freedom. When I started the movement 25 years ago, the only way I could have freedom was through developing an operating system and that was going to take years. If I were thinking short term, I would have said: "Oh, it's so far ahead. I give up!", and I would have let the developer of the proprietary software have power over me the same way everyone else was doing. But instead I thought long term, and I thought: "Yes, it would take years, but it is worth it!" Today, we have free operating systems, we have thousands of free applications, and as a result, choosing freedom doesn't require you to work for many years any more. Now, at most, it requires an inconvenience every so often.

Q But why should developers be working on free software?

I am not saying that everybody should develop free software. If you don't feel like developing free software then you don't have to, because lots of other people will. I certainly don't want to pressure anyone into spending his time writing free software if he is not interested in doing so. But what you should not do is release proprietary software, because that is denying freedom to somebody else. It is not legitimate and is unacceptable for anyone to do that. So, if you are developing software to release, you must make it free software. But you don't have to develop software to release it.

Now, we should know that most people who are paid to write software are writing custom software. There is a particular client that wants a particular program, and he is paying them to write it. This client should, of course, insist on receiving the product they paid for as free software and that should be capable of running on a completely free platform. Because, otherwise, they are paying to lose their freedom. They still have to pay some people to write solutions, because this is not something people would want to volunteer for otherwise. So, companies have to pay and this means that most people who get paid to program free software won't change things much. It may increase their productivity somewhat, but it won't change things much.

Q There's been a lot of confusion between free software and open source. Would you like to say something about it?

Once Linux was put together with the GNU operating system in 1992 to make a complete free operating system, people started distributing the GNU/Linux operating system and telling friends about it, and they were mainly techies. People accustomed to judging software in technical terms, recommended the system to other people looking at the practical advantage of GNU/Linux systems and they did not mention these ethical issues.

Meanwhile, we in the free software movement were talking about these ethical issues. Some people listened to us and others listened to them. So during the 90s, a split, an argument, arose within the community between the people who valued the freedom and community above all and the people who only valued practical convenience.

In 1998 this group, which valued only superficial practical values, chose the term open source as a way